

FLIGHT OF A VERDANT DRAGON



LIFE AND LEGACY OF THE EMERALD EMPEROR

2nd edition

As approved by Jade Council decree

Written by:

VEN. HUI TZU

PREFACE

It is with the utmost seriousness
that this one accepts
the honourable task of writing
his lowly retelling
of his great Nation's glorious birth.

It is this humble ones aspiration
that the retelling of our shared past
will serve to unify
the many noble families,
and by conserving our past
will help to consolidate
our future.



PRaise TO THE EMPEROR, THE CHOSEN OF HEAVEN

Long before the first pagoda stood on the cliffs of Nuoi Dan, before even the ancient terraces of the Yamnai hills were cut into bare stone, the lands of Zhi-La lay at the bottom of the Sea of Whispers. It was a cruel time, for the brown eyed men and women of that land could not breathe there of their own accord, and so the mighty fish-dragons of old would keep them as their servants and force them to do their bidding, lest the great beasts of the sea take away their living breath and they be crushed beneath the churning tide.

In time, among them was born a Child, fair of visage, and with emerald eyes, and the sons and daughters of Zhi-La spoke fondly of this child, for it bore the sign of prophecy. The Child grew up in secret, in the underwater caves where dwelled the fish-dragon's captive mortals, slowly succumbing to the translucent rot that came from the putrid waters. But the child never sulked, never cried out in the gloom and darkness of the undersea cavern that were its home. But sometimes, it is said, when left alone for a short while and thinking himself unobserved, one of the elders would catch the Child, smiling, looking up towards the cavern ceiling as if knowing some secret of the world above the waves.

The Child was raised by the eldest among the servile humans and beastmen, whose frail and battered bodies rendered them useless in the building of their foul masters' undersea temples and cities, who could not cultivate crops of seaweed nor herd the giant lobsters that formed the majority of their masters diets along the seafloor. These elders, kept alive by what little others could spare off their plates, knew the stories of their people, the ancestral tales, the legend of the green eyed child to come. And so it was them who told the Child whom they had kept hidden for a decade to flee when one night, a band of cruel kuo-toa came led by their sea elf overseers in search of an anomalous youth their priests had seen in visions. For the Child had grown powerful, and when the child wept, the seas stirred.

Refusing to give up the Child, the Elders were murdered one by one as He watched from a rocky overhang and, as He quietly shook with grief, from outside the cave there came an answer. A waterborne roar that shattered the gills of fish far and wide resonated through the cavern and within mere moments, the massive head of a vast Dragon Turtle burst through the cavern wall, bringing thousands of tonnes of water along with it which began to fill up the cave. It did not charge, however, but rested its head on the rising water and opened its gargantuan maw. Fearless, the child stepped in, and seeing no alternative, after no slight hesitation many others followed.

As the great Dragon Turtle withdrew, the cavern collapsed. The oceans roiled and the sea floor shook, and the fish-dragon's cities were buried in the dust. But a single, silvery tentacle lashed out at its hind leg, and corruption took hold. As the creature surfaced, it opened its maw and three generations saw the blue sky for the first time in a thousand years. It was then that the Child noticed grave expression in the Dragon Turtle's eyes. It was dying. Its mouth still open wide, it let out one last sigh, and lights flowed from it towards the Child. Its Spirit went into the Child, and its body fell apart as a log amidst a fire, collapsing until its very skin and bone hardened in the midday sun. By sunset, it had sprouted forests, and birdsong could be heard from the canopy.

So was born the land. So was born its Emperor.

PRaise TO THE EMPEROR, WHOSE SHOULDERS CARRY THE EARTH!

On the shores of the Liminal Deep, looking out over the vast ocean that had once been their sky, a group of shaken refugees, a mere few hundred in number stood awestruck. A single green eyed Child had fulfilled a prophecy only few of them believed would ever come true. Even fewer believed it could happen in their lifetime. But so it was and there they stood.

The Child, knowing what was expected of Him, carefully ascended one of the black, jagged rocks that had washed ashore overnight, and looked upon the black sands that hugged the new coast. He stood there for a few seconds, the silence tangible, and then began to speak. ‘My friends, my dear friends! Do you see what has happened here? We have been given a new beginning. A chance to create a better society. Have we not prayed for this to whoever would listen?’ And many agreed with Him. Many nodded, some made noises of agreement, some lowered their heads in respect. Others muttered: ‘what has this Child ever suffered that we have not suffered more?’ and shook their fists at him.

The Child spoke again: ‘here the sea gave us land. The Dragon Turtle gave its life, its soul, its body so that we may live. Here is our home, under sun and sky. Here is our Zhi-La!’ And the people rejoiced. But not all were happy to see the Child tower over their brothers and sisters. Not all were happy to hear his wisdom. Some carried murder in their hearts.

A few days passed, as the survivors built a makeshift camp out of driftwood under an overhanging cliff. Hungry, groups of hunters went out to catch wildlife but to no avail, for no animals had yet settled the newly formed land. Fishermen threw lines out from the beachfront, but the waters were still disturbed from the turmoil, and no fish dared come near the continental shore. Rations ran low. Desperation took hold. The Child was surely blessed, but no one had taught him how to rule, how to organise men and make them work together as a whole.

Jao Xi was an Elder who thought himself of great importance, for he had once been the wine pourer for the fish-dragon Myrthmouth, a most influential aberration among its peers and the sole occupant of a lavish undersea palace. Now, he was in damp clothes on a shore of black volcanic glass, and towering cliffs surrounded the narrow beachfront. “Hear me, men of the Deep, my brothers and sisters on this hostile shore! Surely this child has led us here to die! Was it not one of the creatures from the deep, a Dragon Turtle, that brought us here? Was it not a creature from the deep that gave the Child His power? Surely, He has been tainted and means for us to starve!

The Elders drew near, those who believed the Child and those who believed Jao Xi. And a fight broke out among them. And as their discontent reached its crescendo Jao Xi himself closed his hands around the Child’s neck, and began to strangle him. At this, a rumble passed through the land, and within an instant it began to sink. The water crawled swiftly up the beach and up to Jao Xi’s ankles. Jao Xi and his co-conspirators prostrated themselves before the Child then and begged His forgiveness.

And so it came to be that there is a higher and lower nobility – the Jade Council and the lesser nobles – from the Elders that believed in the Child, and those who turned against Him.

PRaise TO THE EMPEROR WHO SHELTERS THE FAITHFUL

Weeks turned to months, and in spite of the hardships that had divided them so, the settlers survived. From the loyal Elders were appointed councilmen, knowledgeable builders and craftsmen were summoned, and a plan was conceived. They felled the thick bamboo growing just inland and built a dock on the sea shore from where to send fishing boats out to sea. And the Child saw their efforts and was pleased.

It was in the third month after their landfall that the monsoon came. Water began to pour from the sky as if the primordial sea sought to reclaim the land. Storms blew inland, sending the waves crashing far on the beach, swallowing back up the salted fish that were strung up to dry on the beachfront. Raging winds ripped the very roofs from the makeshift houses the survivors had built for themselves, and much of what was built, was lost.

The people cowered in fear under a rocky outcrop, hugging their children tightly as what little they had was shredded by the storm. The roaring skies were dark and threatening, and the many cooking fires that normally brightened the coastline at night had all been extinguished.

But not all were fearful. At the the furthest edge of the outcrop, on a small pedestal of rocks, sat the Child, as regal as any ruler has ever sat on any throne. And He smiled, his eyes half closed.

As the people watched, an indentation appeared in the cliffside, with stairs at the bottom and growing further and further upwards. And at every 40 steps a porticulis appeared, leading into a hollow, until 21 such hollows had formed. A final great rumble sent a pillar of stone up towards the heavens. A tower, tall as the cliffside itself, was raised from it, its peak high above the rocks that held the hollows.

The people were awestruck at this display of power, and they pressed their faces to the wet earth in reverence. But the Child spoke: 'Arise, brothers, sisters. Arise, Elders, and arise, children, for it is not I, but the Land that has given you refuge. And the people took shelter, and they feared no more.

The young and strong went out to gather what supplies they could salvage as the winds continued to blow. Children gathered sticks and mothers lit their small cooking fires in the dry shelters, each of which contained its own small fireplace carved out into the rock.

That night, over a fire in the 11th of the 21 hollows, which was deeper than all the others and offered a large, communal space, the Child gathered the Elders of each noble family unto him. And it was there that he revealed His left hand, turned to green stone. There had been a price, and he had paid it. It was there and then that the Elders swore their fealty: to protect him as he had protected them.

The Child accepted their fealty gladly, his smile radiant as ever. He would protect them and the city he had given them. Their new home. Their Nuoi Dan.

And so it came to be that Nuoi Dan, First City of Zhi-La was founded.

PRAISE TO THE EMPEROR WHO RULES OVER BEAST AND MAN

Months turned to years, and the settlers prospered. Slowly, the village of Nuoi Dan became a proper town. The rudimentary hollows were furnished, small windows were carved and wooden hatches placed over them, and the indented walkways were expanded with strong hardwood beams to support platforms on which market stalls were built. An inside tunnel was carved, connecting the tower to the hollows via a central circular stairway, and it was discovered the many small fireplaces connected to a long upright chimney, creating a strong upward air current. Down by the docks, but well above sea level, a furnace was built and connected to the same system, each addition increasing its effectiveness. Such was the foresight of the Child, who by now had grown into a young man.

Throughout his youth he has displayed an exceptional wisdom, and the Elders of the council would seek him out when they had a disagreement, and he would always resolve it in a way that all parties agreed was rational and just. And so, when he came of age, he was placed at the head of the Council to guide and watch over them, as all knew he must. Years passed, and there were those that set out to seek the riches of the land, and many found the land welcoming. Its many small hills and myriad little rivers offered plentiful opportunities for farming, mining and catching the freshwater shrimp that thrived in the meandering rivers. Animals too had made landfall after the churning of the oceans, and carved out their niche in the emerald-green forests, the rolling green hills, and the thick, unforgiving jungle that met the mountains at the heart of the continent.

As the population exploded, the people expanded east, and to their surprise they were not alone. For past the far southeast jungle, a population of beastfolk had built their homes at the mouth of the river Ajka. First, a few settlers disappeared. Then, a search party. The people became fearful of the lands to the southeast, for they knew not who dwelt there, nor what had become of their brethren. The town of Nuoi Dan had grown into a small city-state by then, and from the city's youths the Council put together a small expeditionary force of a few hundred men armed with weapons and armor from the First City's Forge. But when, after their long march south, they arrived in the lands of the beastfolk, they were met by an army of thousands.

Desperation set in, for here they were in a strange land, surrounded by an army that outnumbered them tenfold, and their mighty leader had stayed behind to protect the First City. So great was their despair that Pai Fo Lin, who had commanded the expedition, fell to one knee and opened his mouth to swear fealty to the beastfolk's chieftain. Before he could utter a word, the earth itself opened up and swallowed him whole. And when the earth did close again, the shape of a young man arose out of bare stone, and spoke.

'You live here because I have let you. Man and beast alike. Do not forget me so easily, for I am the Land upon which you stand armed and opposed to one another.' And a tremor went through the land, and each and every one went to their knees, not in treason, but through His might alone. And the voice spoke once more: 'Let it now be the land upon which you make your peace'. And a promise was made then, that both beast and man had been given this land upon which to live and thrive, and they should abide one another.

And that is how the Beastfolk of Kayar Mau joined the Men and Mer of Nuoi Dan.

PRaise TO THE EMPEROR, MAY HE REIGN A THOUSAND YEARS!

Returning home, the expeditionary forces felt disgraced, for they had indeed forgotten the Emperor's power, and his promise of protection. He had sent them to be his representatives, and instead he'd had to herd them like so many stubborn sheep. Surely he would punish them as he'd punished Pai Fo Lin. Arriving back at the First City, they began the long climb up to the stone-wrought tower, up the winding stairs, and out into the courtyard of the recently built palace that now crowned the cliff like a radiant jewel.

In the great council hall, across the polished tile floor and flanked by ten seats of darkest pallsander on each side, on a throne of even darker stone sat a young man with a beautiful smile that did not reach his eyes, for his eyes bore the weight of ages past, far beyond his years among them. He slumped slightly to the side, and a cloth slipped off his body, and revealed his arm, petrified up to the elbow in green semi-translucent stone. There had been a price, and he had paid it.

The soldiers cried out in shame, and clawed and tore at their clothes and hair until a booming voice stopped them. "I have made an example so that you would not shame yourselves. Do not tread upon the fruits of my labour, but savour them so that all may benefit!" And it was on that day that the First City's armies swore a special oath to uphold him as their ruler, and to repay the debt of flesh and bone that had been established at Kayar Mau. And the city was gathered, and the Council, the Military and the People came together, and they named him Emperor Gu Lahn Sha, the Emerald Emperor, for the price he'd paid for power, and for the green of his eyes.

Many years passed. The people prospered like never before, establishing trade over the vast ocean seas, and establishing many new towns and villages all over the Zhilan continent. Marriages of honour with the daughters of a few of the great houses gave the Emperor many sons. And when after a long and fruitful life, his final days were upon him, the Emperor summoned his eldest Son to him in his chambers. It is not known what was said behind closed doors that night, and it is perhaps good that some things remain between father and son.

It is known fact that the next morning, the council was summoned to the great council hall. It was a chilly spring morning, and the Emperor sat one last time on his throne of precious polished rock, amidst the halls his people had built to honour him. Soon, he was surrounded by representatives from the great honourable houses of the Empire of Zhi-La, his many wives and concubines behind his throne, his children along the aisle, and his eldest, step by step approaching the throne.

He took his sons hands in his own.

Knowing looks passed from father to son, from Emperor, to Prince, and lights began travelling from old and frail hands to strong and youthful ones, and by the time the lights faded, only the younger of the two remained alive.

So ends the tale of the Emerald Emperor. So begins his Dynasty.